Listening tasks: standard and evidence statement

For the admissions team and the English team. October 2026, first version of the pack.

1. Summary

- **The listening standard was set by design, not by trial.** Every listening task was written to a fixed specification (Section 2), and each was checked by a second reviewer: is every answer actually said in the script, do the questions follow the script's order, are the marks right? **No task has yet been tried with students, and none has been calibrated against a standardised test or the CEFR.**
- **The band cut-offs are professional judgement.** For example, in Years 4 to 10, 0 to 2 is band A and 8 out of 8 is band E. They were set before any student took the test, so they are provisional.
- **What the scripts contain** is measured in Section 3. In Years 4 to 10 the scripts are short everyday texts of 150 to 270 words. About 80% of their words are among the 1000 most common words in English, and 85 to 94% are among the 2000 most common. The texts are read twice, and students see or hear the questions first.
- **What a score can show.** The task is designed to separate students who are new to English (band A), early learners (B) and developing learners (C). It is weaker at telling competent students (D) from fluent ones (E), especially in Years 7 to 10. A full score shows secure everyday listening, not that the student can follow age-level lessons in English.
- **Before the bands are used as evidence of a student's level**, carry out the checks in Section 5: record the scripts, try them with students whose level the English team already knows, and compare the results with an established listening test.

2. How the standard was set

Step	What was done
Specification	One design for each age phase (`tools/BLUEPRINT.md`, Section 3), written before any task. **Years 1 to 3:** ten spoken instructions on a picture, graded by language structure: one-step naming, then position words, then two-step, then sequence ("before") and condition ("if"). **Years 4 to 10:** a short message, talk or conversation read twice, with eight questions graded from picture choice and key words, to details (numbers, times), to inference (linking two or more statements).
Writing	Each year group's script and questions were written to that design, with original texts in settings students in China know. Distractors were built in deliberately: the wrong times, places and prices are all said in the script.
Review	A second reviewer checked each year group: every answer is clearly said; questions come in the order of the script (the Year 7, 8, 9 and 10 scripts were reordered after this check); distractors are fair; the marks and band guides follow the specification. **The Years 5 and 6 review was stopped before it finished**, so their listening has had only the writer's own check.
Band cut-offs	Set in the specification by judgement: in Years 4 to 10, 0 to 2 A, 3 to 4 B, 5 to 6 C, 7 D, 8 E. Years 1 to 3 use a score out of 10 (Year 1: 8 to 10 is E; Years 2 and 3: 9 to 10 is E).
Not yet done	Trial with students; comparison with an external test; agreement between markers; checking the cut-offs against students' later progress.

3. What the listening tasks contain

Measured from the scripts in the assessor booklets. "Common words" means the share of the script's words that are among the 1000 or 2000 most frequent word forms of English (method in Section 6).

Year	Task	Delivery	Words	Average sentence (words)	Common words: top 1000 / top 2000	Items	Less common words in the script
1	10 instructions on a bedroom picture	each said once; one repeat allowed	99	9	74% / 83%	10	lamp, teddy

Year	Task	Delivery	Words	Average sentence (words)	Common words: top 1000 / top 2000	Items	Less common words in the script
2	10 instructions on a farm picture	as Year 1	110	10	63% / 76%	10	barn, cow, duck, hen, pig, sheep, tractor
3	10 instructions on a park picture	as Year 1	107	8	69% / 84%	10	duck, pond
4	Phone call	question stems read aloud, text twice	169	5	81% / 87%	8	dumplings, supermarket, umbrella
5	Teacher's message about a class trip	questions read aloud, text twice	151	9	82% / 90%	8	workshop, yuan
6	Phone conversation, film night	questions read aloud, text twice	216	7	80% / 91%	8	mooncakes, metres
7	Phone message between friends	one minute to read questions, text twice	206	10	79% / 85%	8	cinema, metro
8	Conversation, charity fair	as Year 7	251	7	83% / 92%	8	stall, folding
9	Conversation, science club trip	as Year 7	239	7	80% / 88%	8	cloudy, umbrella
10	Careers day talk by an engineer	as Year 7	267	11	83% / 94%	8	kilometres

The less common words in Years 1 to 3 are everyday words for young children (farm animals, toys) that general frequency lists rank low; all of them are drawn in the picture.

Question types in Years 4 to 10 (the same pattern every year): Questions 1 to 4, picture choice or tick boxes on key words and simple details, with a distractor said in the script. Questions 5 and 6, a number, time or price heard in connected speech, often next to a different number. Questions 7 and 8, a reason or an inference that joins two or more statements. The answer table in each assessor booklet names the skill and the distractor for every question.

4. What the scores can and cannot show

	The task can show	The task cannot show
Bands A to C	Whether a student understands familiar words, simple details and short connected speech: the main question for admissions (how much English support to plan)	
Bands D and E	Whether a student can follow an everyday message closely and infer from it (Questions 7 and 8)	Whether the student can follow age-level academic listening: a lesson, subject vocabulary, a longer argument, fast or unclear speech
Years 7 to 10	Secure everyday listening	Readiness for IGCSE courses taught in English. Do not rely on this score for that decision: use the reading paper Part C, the writing, and "listening in conversation" from the interview

	The task can show	The task cannot show
Estimated CEFR range	By design and from the features above, the scripts sit at about **A1 to B1**: Questions 1 to 4 about A1 to A2 (short, clear messages; key information), Questions 5 and 6 about A2 (numbers, times and details in simple connected speech), Questions 7 and 8 about B1 (following the main points of clear speech on familiar topics and linking ideas). **This is an estimate, not a calibration.**	A CEFR level for an individual student

Two further limits. The script is read live, so pace, accent and clarity vary from assessor to assessor, and that changes the difficulty. A single eight-mark task also gives a rough measure: one mark can move a student across a band boundary. So use the band alongside "listening in conversation" on the interview record, never on its own.

5. What is needed to evidence the standard

These steps turn the design into evidence the English team can stand behind. Keep the results with this statement.

Step	What to do	Evidence it produces
1. Fix the delivery	Record each year's script once, read by one clear speaker at a steady classroom pace, with the pauses in the script, and play the recording to every candidate. Note the speed in words per minute.	Every candidate hears the same test
2. Trial	Give each year's task to current students in the international programme whose English level the English team already knows: about 6 to 10 per year group, from new to English to fluent, including some fluent English speakers.	Whether fluent speakers score 7 or 8, whether new-to-English students score 0 to 2, and where the cut-offs should sit
3. External anchor	In the same trial, give the students an established listening test with a published CEFR level: for example the free Cambridge English sample tests (Pre A1 Starters, A1 Movers and A2 Flyers for primary; A2 Key for Schools and B1 Preliminary for Schools for secondary), or the placement test the English team already uses.	A defensible link between our bands and a known scale
4. Agree the marking	Two staff mark the first ten scripts on their own, then compare and agree.	Marker agreement
5. Adjust and record	Change the cut-offs if the trial shows they are too high or too low, and note the date and reason in the assessor booklets.	A dated record of the standard
6. Check after a term	After 20 to 30 admissions, compare each student's listening band with the English team's judgement after one term (guide, Section 10).	Evidence that the bands predict how students cope
7. If needed: a harder extension	If Years 7 to 10 decisions need a clear D or E, add a second, age-level listening text (for example a short lesson-style talk with subject vocabulary).	Discrimination at the top of the scale

Trial record (copy for each year group)

Student (code)	Known level (English team)	Listening score / 8 or / 10	Our band	External test result	Agree?

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6. Method notes

- Word counts and sentence lengths were measured from each year's script as printed in the assessor booklet, without speaker names and pause marks. In Years 1 to 3 the script is the ten instructions.
- "Common words" uses the English word frequency lists in the open-source `wordfreq` library (Speer, version 3.1), which combine several large written and spoken sources. Word forms were matched with simple ending rules (for example "rains" to "rain"); names of people and places were left out. The figures describe the language of the scripts. They are not a test of difficulty for any student.
- As a guide to what the figures mean: research on listening suggests that learners need to know about 95% of the words in a spoken text to follow it adequately (van Zeeland and Schmitt, 2013, *Applied Linguistics*). A student who knows the most common 2000 words of English would know about 85 to 94% of the words in these scripts, and pictures and repeated hearing make up part of the gap.
- The CEFR estimates in Section 4 compare the question types with the CEFR's general descriptions of listening at each level (Council of Europe, *CEFR Companion Volume*, 2020). They have not been checked by trial.